

Our mountains are situated at very high altitudes where you get less oxygen, so naturally, athletes develop more endurance practising here. When they go to other international tournaments, that extra stamina will be beneficial," he explained. The four-day tournament witnessed some remarkable individual performances, with several athletes securing multiple medals. Indian Army's Rajeshwar Singh (2 gold, 1 silver in ski mountaineering), ITBP's Kusum Rana (2 gold, 1 bronze in women's nordic skiing), and Siddharth Gadekar of Maharashtra (1 gold, 1 silver in ski mountaineering), among others.

While the Indian Army dominated the competition by clinching the overall top spot, its familiarity with local conditions proved to be a major contributing factor. However, its overall dominance extends beyond that. For decades, the Armed Forces have been instrumental in developing winter sports in India.

The evolving landscape

One of the most significant takeaways from this edition of the KIWG is the growing participation and success of states with limited natural topography for winter sports.

Maharashtra's impressive medal haul (13 medals) and Tamil Nadu's (five medals) demonstrate the increasing accessibility and appeal of winter sports, transcending geographical limitations. Several athletes from

non-winter sport disciplines have also joined the snow revolution in Gulmarg. Tenzin Dolma, the 40-year-old ultra-trail runner from Manali, bagged the gold in the ski mountaineering women's vertical event in only her first-ever KIWG appearance.

Urmila Pable of Maharashtra reached the podium in the women's snowboarding slalom event. The 21-year-old athlete from Navi Mumbai, a professional skateboarder who represented India in Olympic Qualification in 2023, won the bronze. Apart from them, several cross-country cyclists also took part in the four-day event.

While India is still waiting for an athlete to qualify for Milan 2026, its winter sports potential is gaining momentum.

During the closing ceremony, the Union Minister of Youth Affairs & Sports, Mansukh Mandaviya, announced plans to transform Gulmarg into a premier winter sports hub.

This vision can drive increased participation in winter sports and boost the development of mountain communities in India.

Know your sport



Ski Mountaineering

Climbing mountains either on skis or carrying them, depending on the steepness of the ascent, before descending on skis.
Vertical – Sprint – Relay

Snowboarding

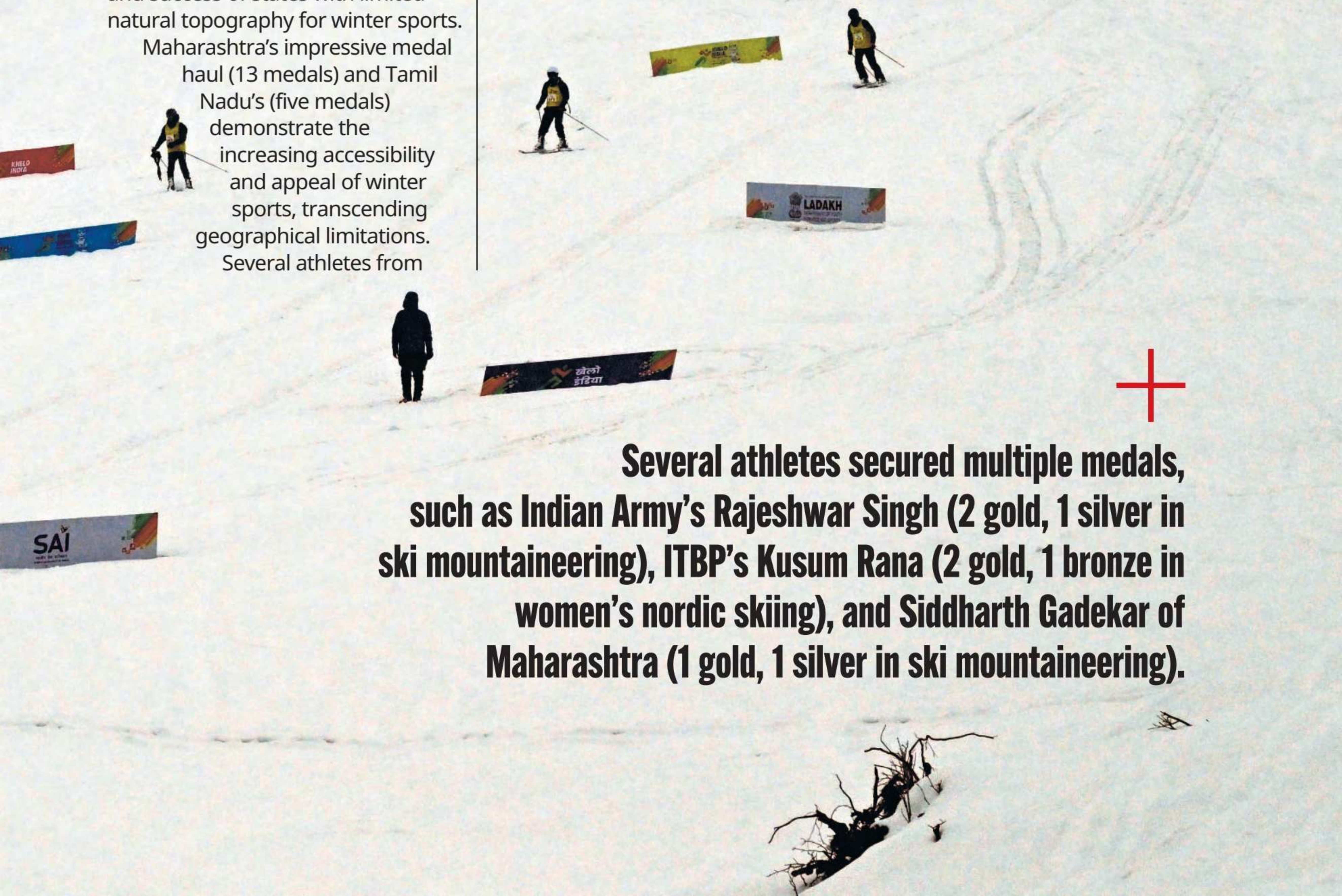
Descending a snow-covered surface while standing on a snowboard, which is almost always attached to the feet.
Slalom – Giant Slalom

Alpine Skiing

Participants ski down a snow-covered mountain slope as quickly as possible.
Slalom – Giant Slalom

Nordic Skiing

The toe of the ski boot is fixed to the binding, allowing the heel to rise off the ski, unlike alpine skiing, where the boot is attached from toe to heel.
10 km – 5 km – 15 km



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